increasingly involved in the affairs of Travancore, initially as an ally in Travancore's war against Mysore and from 1795 onwards as its protector by formal treaty.

With the death of the Dharma Raja in 1798 Travancore's fortunes changed for the worse. The raja's successor, Balarama Varma, was a fourteen-year-old simpleton and a puppet in the hands of a Nambudiri Brahmin named Jayanthan Sankaran. At Sankaran's urging Raja Kesavadas was arrested and proclaimed a traitor, subsequently dying of poisoning. Sankaran now took over as *dalawa* and, in alliance with Thachil Matthoo, proceeded to undo all the good work done by his predecessors, introducing a series of punitive taxes levied on all sections of the community – except the Brahmins and the Syrian Christians.

These events coincided with the British assault on Tipu Sultan's capital at Seringapatam (Srirangapatnam) and the death of Tipu Sultan (of which more in the next chapter). A Hindu ruler was restored to the throne of Mysore as a minor, Tipu's recently won territories were divided up between the Company and the Nizam of Hyderabad, and Travancore and Cochin were recognised as independent but subordinate allies of Britain, with each required to accept a British Resident at court to act both as ambassador and adviser. The first of these Residents was Colonel Colin Macaulay, who had just emerged from the dungeons of Seringapatam after spending two years there as a brutalised prisoner-of-war.[3] No sooner had Macaulay taken up his post in Cochin than he was reporting back to the Governor-General that Travancore was being ruled by 'a triumvirate of ignorance, profligacy and rapacity'.

At this same time the Scots surgeon Dr Francis Buchanan was brought in from Bengal to survey the newly won territories of Mysore, Canara and Malabar.[4] His working brief was to explore these three territories with a view to their commercial potential, but he extended his enquiries to